Chapter Eight

The Second Truce

"The existence of Israel is an error which must be rectified."

—President Abdul Rahman Arif of Iraq

The truce that began on July 18 saw disunity grow between the Arab allies. King Abdullah of Jordan seemed relatively happy with the existing military situation. The Arab Legion occupied territory in central Palestine, and if this were to pass to Jordan's control, Jordan would achieve its main war aim. For this reason, the king seemed to be willing to consider independent negotiations with Israel, while all the other Arab states were vehemently opposed.

There was also friction between the Arab Legion and the Iraqi forces. Jordan had formally been a British protectorate, and the country continued to have a close relationship with Britain even after its independence in 1946. The members of the Arab Legion had been trained by British personnel, carried mainly British weapons, and there were even some British officers serving with the Legion. Many Iraqis regarded this relationship with Britain with deep suspicion and openly wondered whether Jordan was operating secretly in accordance with British wishes to see a partitioned Palestine that included a Jewish state.

Cooperation between the Arab Legion and the Iraqi Army suffered as a direct consequence of these concerns. These divisions and suspicions had always existed, but if the war really had lasted just two weeks as many people had expected, they probably would not have been a major factor. By the beginning of the second truce, it was obvious that the war would not be over soon, and many Arab military leaders had begun to wonder if they could defeat the IDF at all. In these unexpected circumstances, divisions between the Arab allies became more entrenched.

Partly in response to the perceived ambitions of King Abdullah, members of the Arab League met in Alexandria on September 6 to